EXPLORASELF

A NEW WAY OF WINNING

THE LINK TO LEAD MANUAL

12 **PRINCIPLES**

Four stages. Four domains.

Personal leadership for a business worth building and a life worth living.

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EXPLORASELF.COM

A living manual

A New Way of Winning is the parent manual for the personal leadership work of ExploraSelf and Link to Lead. It joins principles, business context, worked situations and practical decisions in twelve main chapters. The book is written for founders, solopreneurs, small business owners, mentors and people preparing to carry greater responsibility.

THE EXPLORASELF APPROACH

Equip the leader and understand the context. Work through purpose, evidence, people and economic reality together. Twelve chapters connect personal leadership to decisions you can carry into the week.

How to understand the examples

Named cases are invented illustrative situations. They are not client testimonials or claims about actual ExploraSelf results. Financial figures are teaching assumptions in USD, not benchmarks, recommended targets or the reader's numbers. Replace them with your own records before making a decision.

Principles, models and research

The twelve working visuals were created for this book. They organise questions and decisions; they are not validated assessments or scoring systems. P.A.C.E. and the seven clarity points are carried forward from the supplied ExploraSelf material. External research and the standard break-even relationship are credited in the reference notes.

This is an educational manual. Its examples cannot determine the accounting, legal, tax, health or other professional requirements of a specific situation. Where those requirements matter, involve an appropriately qualified person. Responsibility includes knowing when the problem exceeds the tool.

Prepared from the supplied Blueprint workbooks, author material and Link to Lead programme. Leading is developed here as an additional lens of stewardship; the supplied programme contains Building, Growing and Scaling routes.

The work beneath the work

A business gives practical form to choices. It decides which problems receive attention, whose labour is valued, which promises are made and how responsibility is carried when the plan goes wrong. The founder influences those arrangements through visible decisions and through the habits that are rarely discussed. That is why personal leadership belongs at the centre of this manual.

A founder needs context as well as conviction. Courage without economic understanding can create promises the business cannot fund. Technical skill without honest conversation can leave a team unable to act. A beautiful strategy can remain motionless if the person leading cannot choose what to stop. The four domains keep these parts of the situation in view together.

Lead yourself concerns attention, identity, judgment and follow-through. Lead your people concerns relationships, expectations, trust and authority. Lead your business concerns work, money, capacity and reliability. Lead the market concerns the people served, the value promised and the evidence that the promise matters. Each domain changes the others. An unclear offer can create operational chaos; an avoided conversation can become a margin problem.

The book asks you to become more precise about what winning is for. It takes ambition seriously enough to examine the bill: financial, personal and human. It makes room for a life of genuine meaning, including work done well, relationships honoured, faith or conviction lived responsibly, and useful contribution beyond the founder's private success.

You will find twelve main chapters arranged in four parts. Building establishes purpose and an honest promise. Growing gives attention, standards and relationships a workable shape. Scaling develops ownership, economic clarity and reliable systems. Leading examines growth, develops other leaders and carries responsibility through review and repair. These are contexts for learning, not ranks of human worth.

Read with something real beside you: a calendar, a delivery record, a customer message, a question that has remained unresolved. Use the principle to understand the situation and the fieldwork to change one part of it. A written answer becomes useful when it reaches the week and returns with evidence. That is where this book intends to meet you.

The first business you lead

I have come to believe that the business asks something of the person long before it asks for a better marketing plan. It asks you to keep your word, look at what you would rather avoid, speak plainly with people and decide what you are willing to carry. You can learn a great deal about strategy and still leave those questions unanswered.

In my earlier work, I wrote about learning through mistakes: orders, money, promises and the responsibility of being the person in charge. I also wrote about training, mentorship and the seasons in which effort takes a different shape. Those experiences sit behind a conviction I return to: the leader needs equipping as carefully as the business.

I do not want you to become impressive at a life you have never chosen. I want you to understand what you are building, who it serves and what kind of person your way of working is helping you become. There is room for serious ambition here. There must also be room to ask what that ambition is for.

A founder is a father in the sense that bringing something into existence creates a responsibility to care for it. The metaphor matters to me because it joins creation with duty. It calls for patience, provision and the willingness to help what you build mature beyond its dependence on you. The people in a company remain adults with their own agency; leadership honours that agency as it develops it.

Building is also being. Your repeated choices give shape to your standards. Leading is lived in the ordinary: the update sent when promised, the fair price, the difficult conversation, the decision another person is finally allowed to make. I want these pages to help you see those moments with greater clarity and use them with greater care.

You will not need every tool in every season. You will need an honest account of where you are, a reason for the next move and the courage to review what happens. Start there. Keep the person, the people and the economic reality in the same room. Build something you are willing to stand behind.

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Alexandru Cojocari is the founder of ExploraSelf and a leadership mentor based in Rome. His work connects the person behind the business with the people, operating choices and markets they lead.

Twelve main chapters

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Lead yourself

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Lead your people

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Lead your business

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Four stages. Four domains.

The book contains twelve core principles, organised as three chapters in each of four stages. The four domains run through every chapter. Their intersection creates sixteen contexts for judgment; it does not create sixteen additional chapters or a score you have to pass.

DOMAIN	BUILDING	GROWING	SCALING	LEADING
Lead yourself	Purpose and honest commitment	Attention and workable boundaries	Judgment and founder capacity	Meaning, example and stewardship
Lead your people	Clear expectations and support	Truth, standards and agreements	Ownership with usable authority	Leaders and continuity
Lead your business	A deliverable, economic promise	A dependable working rhythm	Money, capacity and systems	Resource choices and resilience
Lead the market	A real problem and useful offer	Customer understanding and trust	A repeatable promise at greater volume	Responsible growth and lasting value

Emphasis changes; the whole remains

Building gives special attention to the founder and the people the offer serves. Growing emphasises attention, agreements and consistent work. Scaling deepens economic and operational capacity alongside shared authority. Leading examines purpose, judgment, continuity and consequence. All four domains remain relevant in each context.

The parts are useful starting points, not a demand to pursue endless expansion. A solopreneur can practise stewardship while remaining small. A large company can need to rebuild an offer or restore an elementary standard. Choose by the work required, then follow its dependencies.

LEADING

Leading is the book's fourth context. It develops stewardship, succession, contribution and the freedom to choose an appropriate scale. It is an editorial extension of the three supplied programme routes, not a claim that a fourth online route is already available.

From a reaction to a responsible move

P.A.C.E. supplies a pause in which judgment can work: Pause, Assess, Choose, Execute. The programme opens that movement into seven clarity points. These points are held in the same order throughout the manual and workbooks. The relationship is practical, rather than a validated measurement model.

CLARITY POINT	THE WORK IT ASKS FOR
Name it	State the issue in plain language. Give the work a visible subject.
Evidence	Open, count, observe or quote something another person could inspect.
Gap	Compare the statement with the record. Include what remains uncertain.
Cost	Name the consequence in time, money, people or missed work.
Decision	Choose the part that is yours to own. State the boundary.
Move	Make the proportionate action specific, owned and dated.
Review	State what you will check, when, and with whom.

Keep the answer attached to a source

A remembered impression can begin the inquiry. It should not impersonate a record. Write whether a number is actual or approximate, give the period and currency, and preserve missing information as missing. Ask how the evidence was obtained and whether it can answer the question being asked.

A machine can total hours, compute a margin or draft a summary. The founder still chooses what the figure means for a promise, a boundary or a person. Every calculation in this manual points back to an owned decision. A clear decision is then tested through action and review.

Start where the responsibility is

Read Chapters 1-3 to establish the shared foundation. Then use the decision index and the stage map to choose the issue most relevant to the work in front of you. Return to earlier principles when a later move depends on something still unresolved. Reading selectively is different from pretending a dependency has been completed.

YOUR SITUATION	START HERE	WHAT TO CHECK FIRST
You are finding a useful offer	Chapters 1-3	Purpose, named people, evidence and delivery economics
Demand exists, but the week is unmanageable	Chapters 4-6	Attention, standards and avoided agreements
The work needs more capacity or other owners	Chapters 7-9	Authority, money, capability and reliability
You are choosing what the business becomes	Chapters 10-12	Purpose, growth consequences, leadership and continuity

Do now, prepare next, postpone deliberately

Do now means the move that protects an obligation or addresses the demonstrated constraint. Prepare next means creating the conditions a later move will need. Postpone means a conscious decision with a reason and a review date. It is not an elegant name for avoidance. Each chapter gives a practical distinction among the three.

Do not use the order of a book to delay an urgent safety, cash, legal or conduct issue. Stabilise the immediate obligation and involve appropriate expertise where necessary. Then return to the causes and arrangements the incident revealed.

The book can support a twelve-module teaching sequence, one main chapter per module. In independent use, pace it according to action and review. Existing online levels and workbook gates remain as supplied; the reference section links their exercises to the principles here without silently changing the live programme.

WHAT COUNTS AS PROGRESS

An inspectable answer, a decision someone owns, an action that happened and a review that made the next commitment clearer. A filled page alone is not evidence of a changed business.

BUILDING

Find a reason and a useful promise.

01 02 03 04 05 06 07 08 09 10 11 12

BUILDING GROWING SCALING LEADING

YOU ARE HERE / CHAPTERS 01-03

Bring into Building

A question

What do you want the business to make possible, and for whom?

A record

Bring a calendar, an account of the work and a willingness to examine the evidence.

A first move

Choose one live decision. The next three chapters help you give it a useful foundation.

The next three chapters

01 / Decide what winning is for

Write a definition of winning and use it on one live decision.

02 / Become someone you can rely on

Make a meaningful commitment you can realistically support.

03 / Meet reality and make a useful promise

Connect a real customer problem with a promise you can test.

AHEAD / GROWING 04-06

Attention / standards / truth and care

AHEAD / SCALING AND LEADING 07-12

Capacity / judgment / contribution and continuity

PERSONAL INTERNAL

LEAD YOURSELF

Who is leading the person who carries it all?

Attention, identity, judgment and follow-through.

CHAPTERS WITH THIS MAIN FOCUS

01 / 02 / 04

All four domains meet in Chapter 12.

Before Chapter 01 / Building

01

CHAPTER

PRIMARY DOMAIN / LEAD YOURSELF

Decide what winning is for

THE PRINCIPLE

A worthwhile business begins with a definition of a worthwhile life.

If this worked, what would become possible - and for whom?

CONNECTED THROUGH ALL FOUR DOMAINS

Lead yourself | Lead your people | Lead your business | Lead the market

MAIN FOCUS

01 / Decide what winning is for

PRINCIPLE 01

A worthwhile business begins with a definition of a worthwhile life.

You can build a business that pays you well and still struggle to explain what the money is making possible. Perhaps the answer used to be obvious. You wanted independence, security, a chance to make something properly. Then the business grew. More people needed you. More opportunities arrived. Somewhere along the way, the question changed from what you were building it for to how you could keep all of it moving. Keeping it moving can occupy a life.

Purpose gives direction to the work. Meaning is also found in the care with which you do it: a promise kept, a useful problem solved, a person treated fairly when a shortcut was available. You do not need an extraordinary mission statement before you can act responsibly. You need a reason strong enough to help you choose between two ordinary requests on a difficult Thursday.

Winning, in this manual, means creating useful value, earning enough to sustain it, honouring the people involved, and building a life you can stand behind. These are obligations to consider together. A business can be useful and financially fragile. It can be profitable and cruel. It can look admirable from outside while consuming the person who leads it. An honest definition of success makes those contradictions visible before they become permanent arrangements.

Begin with enough. Name the income, time, relationships, contribution and financial resilience you are trying to support. An amount is a planning input; it is not a measurement of your worth. Enough can change as responsibilities change. Write the reason for the change, so that an expanding target does not quietly become a substitute for knowing what you want.

Then give ambition a job. Perhaps you want to employ people well, make a service accessible, support your family, or build work that outlives your direct involvement. Let the ambition earn its place through those consequences. A larger business is one possible instrument. A smaller, stronger one may serve the purpose better. You are allowed to examine both without turning either choice into a moral identity.

The principle in the whole business

Lead yourself

Open your calendar and spending record. Find evidence of the life your current business is financing and the life it is postponing. Name one commitment you are willing to protect before the next revenue milestone. A future reward should not make every present obligation negotiable.

Lead your people

List the people affected by your ambition, including collaborators and those at home. Ask one what your current pace makes easier and harder for them. Their answer does not decide your purpose, but it belongs in an honest account of its cost.

Lead your business

Translate purpose into an operating requirement: money available for pay, a dependable delivery standard, an affordable workload, or a reserve you deliberately choose. State the time period. Purpose becomes practical when it changes what you accept, fund or refuse.

Lead the market

Name whose situation improves when your business works. Ask what the improvement means in their day. A customer may want a reliable appointment rather than participation in your grand vision. Respect the problem they actually brought you.

THE ATTRACTIVE CONTRACT

Illustrative case. Elena is offered a contract that would increase sales but requires evening availability throughout the week. Her stated reason for founding the business includes dependable family time. She asks about response windows, delivery dates and support before deciding. The contract might be reshaped, priced to fund coverage, or declined. The principle does not supply the answer. It prevents her from calling the trade-off free.

Purpose cannot cancel a binding obligation or pay an overdue bill. During a cash shortage, a founder may accept temporary work outside the preferred direction. Name the reason, the limit and the review date. Temporary compromise becomes dangerous when it quietly becomes the business model.

The four tests of a worthwhile win

Use all four tests on one live decision. A tension is a prompt for redesign or a conscious trade-off; it is not a numerical score.

USEFUL VALUE

Whose situation improves?

VIABILITY

What funds the promise?

PEOPLE

Who carries the work?

LIFE

What does repetition create?

HOW TO USE THE MODEL

Write the offer or opportunity in the centre. Around it, ask what changes for the customer, what funds the work, what happens to the people carrying it, and what kind of life repeated acceptance would create. An empty answer is a request for evidence. It is not permission to fill the gap with optimism.

A TEST IN THE REAL WEEK

Before committing, describe the decision to someone who knows what you say matters. Ask them to name the cost you have minimised. You retain responsibility for the choice. Their job is to help you see the whole exchange.

A QUESTION WORTH STAYING WITH

If this worked, what would become possible - and for whom?

FIGURE 01 / ExploraSelf working model / A New Way of Winning

Turn the principle into a move

01 Name it

Write what you want the business to make possible in the coming year.

02 Evidence

Open the last month of your calendar and accounts; record two facts that support or contradict that intention.

03 Gap

Name the largest mismatch between your definition of winning and the pattern you can see.

04 Cost

Describe who carries that mismatch, and the time, money or attention it takes.

05 Decision

Choose one opportunity or commitment to accept, reshape or refuse.

06 Move

Record the exact conversation or calendar change and its date.

07 Review

Set a review date and name the evidence that would show the choice served its purpose.

DO NOW	PREPARE NEXT	POSTPONE DELIBERATELY
Write a one-paragraph definition of winning and use it on one actual decision.	Build a simple financial picture that shows what your chosen life requires from the business.	Delay public promises about scale until the purpose and practical obligations are clear.

WHAT YOU LEAVE WITH

Your definition of winning; one decision tested against it; one dated change.

Keep this definition beside the evidence ledger in Chapter 3. Revise it deliberately, rather than whenever an opportunity flatters you.

02

CHAPTER

PRIMARY DOMAIN / LEAD YOURSELF

Become someone you can rely on

THE PRINCIPLE

The founder is a person before a role, and character is practised in ordinary commitments.

Who am I becoming through the way I repeatedly work?

CONNECTED THROUGH ALL FOUR DOMAINS

Lead yourself | Lead your people | Lead your business | Lead the market

MAIN FOCUS

02 / Become someone you can rely on

PRINCIPLE 02

The founder is a person before a role, and character is practised in ordinary commitments.

A founder can become very good at explaining the business and very poor at describing the person living inside it. The role supplies a ready-made answer: busy, needed, responsible. Those descriptions may be accurate. They do not tell you whether your habits support the life you intended to build. Personal leadership starts by noticing the difference between being required and being dependable.

Dependability begins with promises small enough to keep and important enough to matter. You do not need to reinvent your personality this week. Choose a commitment that will make your own conduct more trustworthy: prepare before the meeting, say when you cannot deliver, keep a protected appointment, or ask for help before the problem becomes somebody else's emergency. Confidence can then rest on a record of action rather than a speech you give yourself.

Your dignity survives a poor month. Your responsibilities still require attention. Holding those two truths together makes honest examination possible. When every operational mistake becomes a verdict on your worth, evidence feels threatening and correction becomes difficult. When self-acceptance excuses every repeated failure, other people pay for the comfort. A mature founder can say both that they matter and that this behaviour must change.

The person behind the business also lives in a body and a social world. Capacity varies with health, care responsibilities, financial pressure and support. A routine must fit the life that has to carry it. Borrowing someone else's heroic schedule can create a performance of discipline while undermining the very work it was meant to support.

In self-determination theory, Ryan and Deci describe autonomy, competence and relatedness as important needs in motivation and well-being [R1]. This provides a useful reminder to examine the conditions around effort as well as the individual's will. It does not establish a universal founder routine. Here the practical question is whether your commitments are chosen with understanding, supported by learnable skills, and held within relationships where you can be honest.

The principle in the whole business

Lead yourself

Find a promise you keep breaking to yourself. Check whether it is meaningful, feasible and supported by a real time slot. Reduce or renegotiate it where needed. Repeatedly signing an impossible contract with yourself teaches very little beyond disappointment.

Lead your people

Ask a colleague which version of you they receive under pressure. Request a recent example. Listen before explaining. Your intention matters, and their experience adds information your intention cannot supply. Choose a repair that they can observe.

Lead your business

Create a minimum operating rhythm that survives an ordinary difficult week. Name the checks that protect delivery, cash and customer communication. Make room for preparation and recovery within the capacity you actually have.

Lead the market

Separate professional visibility from the need for personal approval. Review one piece of communication: is it useful to the person reading, and can you support its claim? Being impressive is an unreliable substitute for being clear.

THE ROUTINE THAT KEPT FAILING

Illustrative case. Daniel decides to work before dawn every day while already covering late customer calls. After repeatedly missing the routine, he calls himself undisciplined. His calendar shows that the plan depended on hours he had already committed elsewhere. He replaces the heroic routine with two protected planning sessions and changes the call window. The first improvement is an arrangement he can keep, not a new identity to announce.

A commitment record is a learning aid, not a moral ranking. Illness, emergencies and unequal conditions affect what someone can do. Distinguish an avoidable pattern from a genuine limit. Where distress or health concerns require professional care, a business exercise cannot replace it.

The person, the roles, the commitments

Roles organise responsibility. They do not contain the whole person. Read this diagram from the centre outward.

THE PERSON

Dignity / conviction / relationships / health / service

FOUNDER

Role and obligations

COLLEAGUE

Role and obligations

FAMILY / COMMUNITY

Role and obligations

HOW TO USE THE MODEL

At the centre, name the human commitments that give direction: dignity, faith or conviction, relationships, health and service. Around them sit the roles you currently carry. Around each role, list observable obligations. When two obligations conflict, negotiate the arrangement rather than pretending you have become two people.

A TEST IN THE REAL WEEK

Choose a seven-day commitment with a clear place and time. Write what you will do if the normal slot fails. At review, examine the conditions and the action. Keep, adapt or release the commitment according to what it taught you.

A QUESTION WORTH STAYING WITH

Who am I becoming through the way I repeatedly work?

FIGURE 02 / ExploraSelf working model / A New Way of Winning

Turn the principle into a move

01 Name it

Name the behaviour you want people to be able to rely on.

02 Evidence

Open last week's calendar and messages; record one kept and one missed commitment.

03 Gap

Identify the difference between your intention and the conditions you arranged.

04 Cost

Name the consequence for yourself and one other person.

05 Decision

Choose the smallest meaningful commitment you can realistically support.

06 Move

Put it in the calendar and tell the person affected what to expect.

07 Review

Check the action on a named date and record what helped or obstructed it.

DO NOW	PREPARE NEXT	POSTPONE DELIBERATELY
Repair one missed commitment and create one feasible promise for the next week.	Create a rhythm that protects preparation, review and the personal commitments you named.	Delay adding routines until you can explain which existing obligation will make room for them.

WHAT YOU LEAVE WITH

One repaired commitment, one realistic weekly promise, and a record of what happened.

Bring this record into Chapter 4, where your promises compete for a finite week.

BUSINESS EXTERNAL

LEAD THE MARKET

Whose situation improves because your business exists?

Customers, useful value, evidence and responsible growth.

CHAPTERS WITH THIS MAIN FOCUS

03 / 10

All four domains meet in Chapter 12.

Before Chapter 03 / Building

03

CHAPTER

PRIMARY DOMAIN / LEAD THE MARKET

Meet reality and make a useful promise

THE PRINCIPLE

Responsibility begins by separating what you know from what you hope.

What is true enough to act on, and what still needs testing?

CONNECTED THROUGH ALL FOUR DOMAINS

Lead yourself	Lead your people	Lead your business	**Lead the market**
			MAIN FOCUS

03 / Meet reality and make a useful promise

PRINCIPLE 03

Responsibility begins by separating what you know from what you hope.

A founder needs imagination to begin. They also need a way to notice when imagination has started editing the evidence. Enthusiasm can make a polite conversation sound like demand. Anxiety can make one rejection sound like the end of the market. The work is to keep the event, your interpretation and the decision distinct long enough to examine each.

Evidence is something another person could inspect: a customer sentence, a payment, a delivery record, a dated observation. An estimate can be useful when it is labelled and its limits are understood. An assumption can guide a test when it is written as an assumption. Trouble begins when the label disappears and the business starts spending as if the uncertainty had been resolved.

Your first useful promise connects a real person's problem with a change you can deliver at a workable price. Start close enough to learn. Name the customer, the situation, the outcome, the scope and the terms. Then examine what the person actually does. Payment is strong evidence of willingness to buy a particular offer under particular conditions. It does not prove repeat demand, satisfied use or profitable delivery. Those questions require their own evidence.

The first economic question is simple: after the costs that arise because you deliver the job, what remains to support everything else? Count your own time separately if it has not been paid through the costs. A busy diary can hide an offer that cannot support the founder. Chapter 8 develops the arithmetic; here the obligation is to discover whether the promise has a plausible economic shape.

Under uncertainty, choose a test whose possible loss you can carry. Sarasvathy's account of effectuation provides a theoretical basis for considering controllable commitments alongside prediction [R3]. The working application here is modest: state what you can afford to spend in time, money and reputation, identify the uncertainty, and agree what you will observe before committing more. A small test should produce a clearer decision, rather than a small version of endless activity.

The principle in the whole business

Lead yourself

Write your preferred explanation before examining the record. Then look for what might contradict it. Your attachment to the answer is information about you; it does not make the answer false or true. Seek a test capable of disappointing you.

Lead your people

Ask someone close to the work to distinguish what they have seen from what they infer. Make it possible to say that a plan is unclear. The founder's confidence should not be the price of admission to the conversation.

Lead your business

Map the steps required to fulfil the offer. Record direct costs, founder hours, payment timing and the limit of current capacity. State what is included and excluded. A clear offer is already an instruction to operations.

Lead the market

Ask about a recent instance of the problem: what happened, what they tried, what it cost and what they did next. Avoid turning every answer into a pitch. The customer's account should survive your wish to sell.

PRAISE WITHOUT A PURCHASE

Illustrative case. Mira hears that her workshop sounds useful and rents a larger room. Before committing further, she offers a clearly scoped pilot with a real price and booking deadline. She records purchases, objections and the reasons people give. The pilot also tracks preparation and delivery hours. Whether it fills or not, the next decision has better evidence than the original compliments.

Small samples can reveal questions without establishing a stable market. Silence has several possible explanations, including timing, reach, trust and relevance. Record competing explanations. Avoid declaring a universal truth from a handful of conversations, including a handful of encouraging ones.

The evidence ledger

Move from an inspectable fact to a stated interpretation, then to a test. Keep each label visible.

OBSERVATION	INTERPRETATION	UNCERTAINTY	NEXT TEST
A buyer asks for a lower price.	Budget, value or negotiation?	What is behind the request?	Clarify scope and alternatives.
Something I can inspect	My current explanation	What I do not know	A decision-relevant action

HOW TO USE THE MODEL

Use four columns: observation, interpretation, uncertainty and next test. For example, a prospective buyer asks for a lower price. The observation is the request. Possible interpretations include a budget limit, an unclear offer or an opening negotiation. The test might clarify scope and alternatives. Cutting the price immediately chooses an explanation before checking it.

A TEST IN THE REAL WEEK

Write the decision date and evidence you will accept before the test begins. Record actual cost as it occurs. End with a decision to continue, change or stop, together with the reason. A test without a decision rule easily becomes another ongoing project.

A QUESTION WORTH STAYING WITH

What is true enough to act on, and what still needs testing?

FIGURE 03 / ExploraSelf working model / A New Way of Winning

Turn the principle into a move

01 Name it

State your current offer and the person it serves in one sentence.

02 Evidence

Open payment records, delivery notes and customer messages; record what supports the claim.

03 Gap

Name the most important assumption the records do not establish.

04 Cost

Write the affordable time and money limit of testing it.

05 Decision

Choose one uncertainty to test before expanding the promise.

06 Move

Run the specific test with a scope, owner and date.

07 Review

Compare the result with your prewritten decision rule and record the next choice.

DO NOW	PREPARE NEXT	POSTPONE DELIBERATELY
Speak to one relevant person and test one clearly scoped offer or uncertain claim.	Track whether the work produces the promised change at an acceptable cost.	Delay wider promotion until you can explain what the test established and what remains uncertain.

WHAT YOU LEAVE WITH

An evidence ledger, an offer with boundaries, and one completed test.

Use this ledger whenever confidence or fear tries to substitute for a record.

GROWING

Give the work a human shape.



BUILDING GROWING SCALING LEADING

YOU ARE HERE / CHAPTERS 04-06

Carry forward from Building

01 / A reason

Your definition of winning and what the business is meant to serve.

02 / A record

A dependable commitment and evidence of how you follow through.

03 / A promise

A named customer, a useful offer and a way to test what remains uncertain.

The next three chapters

04 / Give your attention a job

Make room for the work and commitments you choose.

05 / Make your values operational

Turn standards into behaviour, boundaries and repair.

06 / Tell the truth with care

Replace an avoided issue with a workable agreement.

AHEAD / SCALING 07-09

Ownership / economic clarity / reliable systems

AHEAD / LEADING 10-12

Growth choices / leaders / review and stewardship

04

CHAPTER

PRIMARY DOMAIN / LEAD YOURSELF

Give your attention a job

THE PRINCIPLE

The week is where your stated priorities become visible commitments.

What receives my life because I chose it, and what receives it by default?

CONNECTED THROUGH ALL FOUR DOMAINS

Lead yourself | Lead your people | Lead your business | Lead the market

MAIN FOCUS

04 / Give your attention a job

PRINCIPLE 04

The week is where your stated priorities become visible commitments.

Your calendar is an arrangement of claims on a person. Some claims are chosen, some inherited, some accepted because declining them would require an uncomfortable sentence. A crowded week can therefore contain very little deliberate leadership. Before asking how to fit more into it, ask what the existing pattern is protecting and what it repeatedly displaces.

Count the actual week. Include preparation, administration, customer recovery, travel, rework and the tasks that spill into personal time. Separate a recorded hour from an estimated one. The purpose is to make the arrangement visible enough to change. A precise-looking total built from guesses can be less useful than an honest partial record.

Then distinguish work that genuinely requires you from work that reaches you through habit. Unique expertise, formal authority and a specific relationship may justify your involvement. Each also deserves examination. Expertise may be taught. Authority may be distributed within limits. A relationship may be broadened through deliberate introductions. The phrase only me should open a question, not close one.

Your energy is relevant even when it cannot be priced reliably. Two equal blocks of time may have different consequences for the rest of the day. Notice patterns without inventing a scientific score. Ask which tasks require preparation, which drain you, and which conditions help you do important work well. Design around the evidence you can observe.

A protected hour also needs a rule for interruption. Name what is genuinely urgent, who can decide it and where ordinary requests wait. Otherwise the calendar contains an aspiration rather than an agreement. You may still choose to interrupt the block. Record why. Leadership involves exceptions; it also involves noticing when exceptions have quietly become the normal operating model.

The principle in the whole business

Lead yourself

Compare the week you intended with the week that happened. Identify one recurring trade-off you have never consciously accepted. Decide what you will protect and what you are prepared to stop. A priority without displaced work has no place to live.

Lead your people

Count the requests waiting for your answer. Ask what each delay holds up. Some interruptions are symptoms of missing authority or unclear expectations. Fixing the arrangement may protect your attention and theirs more effectively than becoming harder to reach.

Lead your business

Find one repeated task with avoidable rework, waiting or unnecessary attendance. Record the whole cost of a meeting as the time of all participants. Change one element and observe whether the work still gets done properly.

Lead the market

Protect deliberate contact with customers and prospects. Delivery can fill every available hour while future demand receives leftovers. Choose an outward rhythm that fits the business and test whether it produces relevant conversations, rather than merely more visible activity.

THE FOUNDER WHO ANSWERED EVERYTHING

Illustrative case. Luca answers every message immediately because responsiveness feels like service. A week of records shows that his team asks him to approve routine work while customer proposals wait. He gives one colleague clear approval limits and creates two daily windows for ordinary questions. He keeps a separate route for urgent problems. The measure is what happens to decisions and delivery, not how silent his phone becomes.

Some roles require genuine availability. A small business may have limited cover, and immediate customer work may fund the next week. Adapt the rhythm to that reality. The aim is to make the cost and choice explicit, rather than treating every interruption as either sacred or irresponsible.

The attention exchange

Every protected block needs a named source of space. Fill both sides with your own week; the diagram contains no recommended time allocation.

A CLAIM I WILL CHANGE	SPACE IT CAN RELEASE	WHAT THE SPACE WILL SERVE
Reduce / stop / teach / keep	Use your own recorded hours	Name the work or commitment
Allow for training time	Check whether the time is released	Observe who absorbs the change
Review after a real week	Record interruptions honestly	Keep, adapt or reverse

HOW TO USE THE MODEL

On the left, list the recurring claims you will reduce, stop, teach or keep. On the right, name the work and personal commitments the released time will serve. Count only time you can plausibly release. Delegation may require training before it creates capacity; show that initial investment instead of assuming an instant saving.

A TEST IN THE REAL WEEK

Run the revised week once. Record interruptions, unfinished commitments and who absorbed the change. Ask whether the important work moved and whether a hidden burden shifted to somebody else. Protecting the founder's attention is worthwhile when the whole arrangement improves.

A QUESTION WORTH STAYING WITH

What receives my life because I chose it, and what receives it by default?

FIGURE 04 / ExploraSelf working model / A New Way of Winning

Turn the principle into a move

01 Name it

Name the work you say deserves your best attention this week.

02 Evidence

Open the last full week; list the largest blocks and the work that spilled outside them.

03 Gap

Mark what received time without serving the stated priority or a real obligation.

04 Cost

Record the work, recovery or relationship time displaced.

05 Decision

Choose one recurring claim to reduce, stop, teach or keep deliberately.

06 Move

Schedule the released block and explain the new request rule to those affected.

07 Review

At week end, compare the plan with the record and decide what changes next.

DO NOW	PREPARE NEXT	POSTPONE DELIBERATELY
Defend one specific block by removing or changing one competing claim.	Teach or redesign the recurring work that repeatedly takes the block back.	Delay adding productivity tools until you can name the decision the tool will help you carry out.

WHAT YOU LEAVE WITH

A visible week, a changed request rule, and one block used for its intended purpose.

Bring the conflicts you uncover into the standards and conversations of Chapters 5 and 6.

BUSINESS INTERNAL

LEAD YOUR BUSINESS

Can the business keep the promises you make?

Economic clarity, capacity, standards and systems that support dependable work.

CHAPTERS WITH THIS MAIN FOCUS

05 / 08 / 09

All four domains meet in Chapter 12.

Before Chapter 05 / Growing

05

CHAPTER

PRIMARY DOMAIN / LEAD YOUR BUSINESS

Make your values operational

THE PRINCIPLE

A standard is a value with a behaviour, a boundary and a response when it is missed.

What remains true here when keeping it becomes inconvenient?

CONNECTED THROUGH ALL FOUR DOMAINS

Lead yourself | Lead your people | **Lead your business** | Lead the market

MAIN FOCUS

05 / Make your values operational

PRINCIPLE 05

A standard is a value with a behaviour, a boundary and a response when it is missed.

Values are easy to admire when the order book is full and the team is rested. Their meaning becomes clearer when a delivery is late, a customer asks for an exception or an important person behaves badly. Under pressure, a vague value gives everyone room to defend a different interpretation. A usable standard says what people can expect to happen.

Take respect. In one business it means returning a customer update when promised. In another, it means refusing to humiliate a colleague in front of a client. Both need specific conduct, the circumstances in which it matters and a response when it is missed. The word alone cannot carry the agreement.

Standards should protect the purpose of the work, not the founder's preferences disguised as universal truths. Ask what risk or outcome the standard serves. A formatting habit may be negotiable. A safety requirement may not be. An arbitrary rule enforced with passion is still arbitrary. Explaining the reason makes intelligent adaptation possible and exposes rules that no longer earn their cost.

Define finished with the person doing the work and, where relevant, with the customer. A usable finish line can be checked without interpreting the founder's mood. Include the required result, the necessary evidence and the person who accepts it. The definition can evolve, but changes should be named before they are applied to work already agreed.

When a standard fails, examine both conduct and conditions. Was the expectation clear? Was the person equipped and authorised? Was the workload feasible? Did they knowingly disregard the agreement? Different answers call for different responses. Consistency means applying a clear reasoning process, including fair consideration of context. It does not require pretending every failure has the same cause.

The principle in the whole business

Lead yourself

Find one standard you expect from others but waive for yourself. Look for an actual example. Name the repair and the behaviour you will demonstrate next. Your position may explain a different responsibility; it should not silently purchase exemption from the values you announce.

Lead your people

Choose a deliverable whose finish line is disputed. Ask each person to describe done before offering your version. Agree the observable result, support, deadline and check. Preserve the record so that memory does not become the judge.

Lead your business

Write the shortest acceptance check that prevents the recurring failure. Count rework where you can observe it. Improve the rule when it creates waste or misses the real risk. Documentation earns its place through use.

Lead the market

Compare the promise in your sales message with what the customer receives. Where they differ, correct the promise or the delivery. A standard inside the business matters partly because of the experience it makes possible outside.

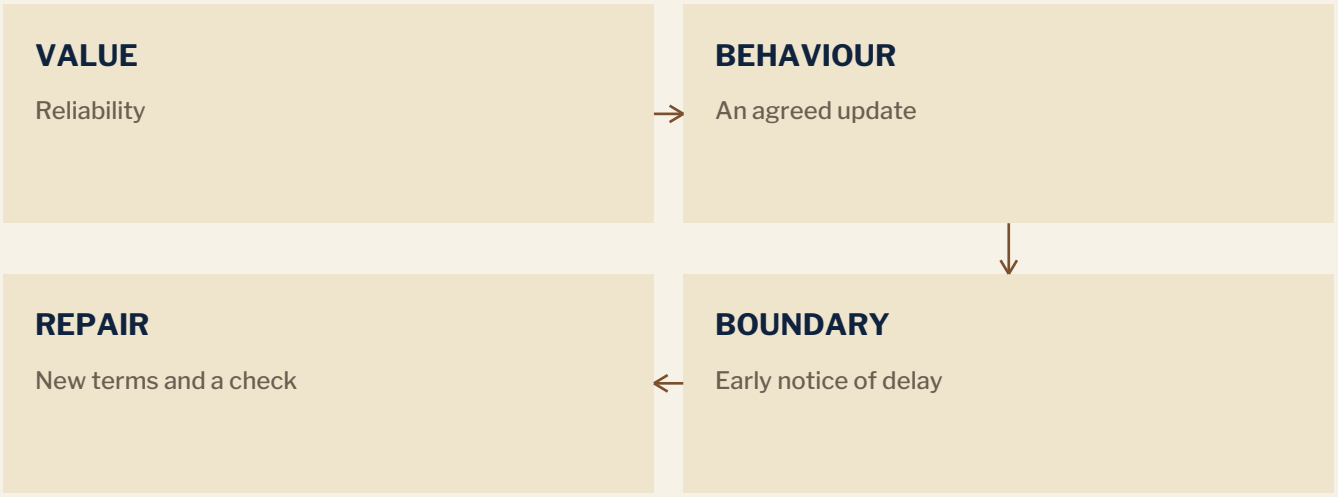
THE MOVING FINISH LINE

Illustrative case. A designer submits work that meets the brief. The founder asks for several rounds of changes because it does not feel premium. They examine recent projects and identify concrete requirements for hierarchy, legibility, proofing and approval. Future work uses that definition. The founder separately pays attention to changes of preference, rather than booking them all as poor execution.

A standard should leave room for professional judgment. Over-specification can make people comply mechanically while missing the purpose. State the non-negotiable outcome and the area where discretion is welcome. Legal, technical and safety obligations require the appropriate specialist standard, not a convenient house interpretation.

From a value to a working agreement

A complete standard names the conduct and the response. The four elements belong together.



HOW TO USE THE MODEL

Write the value, the observable behaviour, the boundary and the repair. For reliability, that might mean a promised update, early notice of a likely delay, a revised agreement and a check that the recipient has what they need. The repair is specific enough to restore the work. It is not a ritual apology designed to end the discussion.

A TEST IN THE REAL WEEK

Apply the agreement to one live deliverable. Ask the person using it where they still had to guess. Adjust the written definition before expanding it. A standard understood differently by the people responsible for it is still under construction.

A QUESTION WORTH STAYING WITH

What remains true here when keeping it becomes inconvenient?

FIGURE 05 / ExploraSelf working model / A New Way of Winning

Turn the principle into a move

01 Name it

Name one value or quality standard you say the business holds.

02 Evidence

Open a recent delivery and its messages; identify the behaviour that supported or contradicted it.

03 Gap

Locate the expectation that remained unwritten or changed after agreement.

04 Cost

Record rework, delay or loss of trust using observable examples.

05 Decision

Agree one definition of finished and the response to a missed condition.

06 Move

Use the definition on a named piece of work and show it to those involved.

07 Review

Check the result together and revise the standard where the evidence requires it.

DO NOW	PREPARE NEXT	POSTPONE DELIBERATELY
Write and use one definition of finished with a clear acceptance check.	Repair any gap between the public promise and the operational standard.	Delay a larger values document until the first standards have been used and improved.

WHAT YOU LEAVE WITH

One standard that names behaviour, boundary and repair, tested on real work.

Use the agreed standard as the factual ground for the conversation in Chapter 6.

PERSONAL EXTERNAL

LEAD YOUR PEOPLE

What becomes possible when people can trust the arrangement?

Truth, expectations, authority and the care that makes responsibility workable.

CHAPTERS WITH THIS MAIN FOCUS

06 / 07 / 11

All four domains meet in Chapter 12.

Before Chapter 06 / Growing

06

CHAPTER

PRIMARY DOMAIN / LEAD YOUR PEOPLE

Tell the truth with care

THE PRINCIPLE

Care takes another person seriously enough to be honest, specific and open to correction.

What conversation would make the situation more workable if I stopped rehearsing it?

CONNECTED THROUGH ALL FOUR DOMAINS

Lead yourself | **Lead your people** | Lead your business | Lead the market

MAIN FOCUS

06 / Tell the truth with care

PRINCIPLE 06

Care takes another person seriously enough to be honest, specific and open to correction.

An avoided conversation continues without you. It speaks through rework, tension, delayed decisions and the private stories people tell about one another. You may be trying to protect the relationship. The unspoken issue may be changing it anyway. Naming the problem gives both people a chance to work with something clearer than accumulated suspicion.

Begin with what you can support. Describe the event, the agreement and the effect. Leave room for information you do not have. You can be firm about a boundary while remaining uncertain about another person's motive. A missed deadline is inspectable. Laziness is an explanation that may or may not survive a proper conversation.

Then ask for their account and listen long enough to learn something. Listening does not require surrendering your responsibility. It helps you choose a proportionate response. Perhaps the work needs clearer authority, training or a different deadline. Perhaps a repeated agreement is being disregarded. Decide after examining the account, and say plainly what will happen next.

In her field study of work teams, Amy Edmondson found an association between psychological safety and learning behaviour [R2]. That finding supports attention to the interpersonal conditions around speaking up; it does not mean agreement, comfort or a guaranteed performance outcome. In this manual, the practical obligation is to make questions and relevant bad news speakable while keeping expectations clear.

Include your part in the agreement. Name the support, information or decision you will provide. State the other person's responsibility, the date and the review. Where consequences are necessary, make them lawful, proportionate and clear. Avoid converting a business conversation into a performance of moral superiority. The aim is a workable truth, including the possibility that some of the correction belongs to you.

The principle in the whole business

Lead yourself

Name what you fear will happen if you speak. Compare it with the evidence from previous conversations. Prepare the first factual sentence and the question that follows it. If you are too activated to listen, arrange a suitable time instead of making the other person carry your first reaction.

Lead your people

Choose privacy and an appropriate setting. State the issue, invite their account, agree what changes and record it. Ask whether they can realistically deliver the agreement. A reluctant yes under pressure may conceal a problem that returns later.

Lead your business

Trace the operational consequence of the silence. Identify the process, authority or standard that also needs changing. Repeatedly asking someone to try harder can conceal a broken arrangement. Repair the arrangement as well as addressing conduct.

Lead the market

Tell customers what they need to know about a delivery problem, including the next reliable update. Make claims you can support. Prompt honesty may be uncomfortable; guessing a reassuring date can create a second failure on top of the first.

THE SUPPLIER NOBODY CONFRONTED

Illustrative case. A founder keeps rescuing late material from a supplier. She records three agreed dates and the actual arrivals, explains the delivery impact and asks what is causing the pattern. They agree a revised confirmation process and a clear limit for future delays. She also identifies an alternative source. The conversation serves the relationship and the business by making the terms visible.

A direct conversation is not always the right first action where there is intimidation, harassment, violence or serious misconduct. Use an appropriate formal process or qualified support. Care includes attention to power and safety; it does not require exposing someone to an avoidable confrontation.

Truth and care in the same conversation

This is a preparation map, not a personality assessment. Use it to examine a planned message, not to label another person.

LOW TRUTH / LOW CARE

Withdrawal or avoidance

HIGH TRUTH / LOW CARE

A verdict without regard

LOW TRUTH / HIGH CARE

Warmth with an unclear issue

HIGH TRUTH / HIGH CARE

Specific truth and workable care

HOW TO USE THE MODEL

Specific truth without care can become a humiliating verdict. Care without specific truth can leave the person guessing. The useful meeting point is a supported observation, an honest question, a clear expectation and a reciprocal commitment. Read your opening aloud and check whether it contains all four.

A TEST IN THE REAL WEEK

After the conversation, record what was said rather than what you predicted would happen. Send the agreed actions in plain language where appropriate. Review the actions on the date you named. A satisfying conversation is only the beginning of a changed working relationship.

A QUESTION WORTH STAYING WITH

What conversation would make the situation more workable if I stopped rehearsing it?

FIGURE 06 / ExploraSelf working model / A New Way of Winning

Turn the principle into a move

01 Name it

Name the conversation and the actual issue in one sentence.

02 Evidence

Open the relevant messages or work record; choose the facts both people can examine.

03 Gap

Identify the expectation, information or conduct that needs clarification.

04 Cost

Describe the continuing cost of leaving it unspoken.

05 Decision

Decide the request, your own contribution and the boundary you will hold.

06 Move

Have the conversation on a named date; record the agreement and owner.

07 Review

Check the agreed actions and ask what still needs repair.

DO NOW	PREPARE NEXT	POSTPONE DELIBERATELY
Have one prepared, appropriate conversation and write down the agreement.	Correct the standard, handoff or authority gap that the conversation exposes.	Delay judgments about motive until you have asked for the person's account.

WHAT YOU LEAVE WITH

A factual opening, a reciprocal agreement and a dated review.

Take the clarified expectations into Chapter 7, where trust becomes usable authority.

SCALING

Build capacity you can trust.



BUILDING GROWING SCALING LEADING

YOU ARE HERE / CHAPTERS 07-09

Carry forward from Growing

04 / Chosen attention

A week that names the work you protect and what makes room for it.

05 / A usable standard

A value expressed through observable behaviour, a boundary and a repair.

06 / A workable truth

A specific conversation, a reciprocal agreement and a date to review it.

The next three chapters

07 / Give ownership somewhere to live

Give responsibility the authority and support it needs.

08 / Read the cost of your promises

Read contribution, cash and capacity before you promise more.

09 / Build systems that keep promises

Make dependable work easier through a tested system.

AHEAD / LEADING 10-12

Growth choices / leaders / review and stewardship

KEEP IN VIEW / ALL FOUR DOMAINS

Lead yourself, your people, your business and the market.

07

CHAPTER

PRIMARY DOMAIN / LEAD YOUR PEOPLE

Give ownership somewhere to live

THE PRINCIPLE

Responsibility becomes workable when authority, capability and support accompany it.

What can another person genuinely own, and what must I provide for that to be fair?

CONNECTED THROUGH ALL FOUR DOMAINS

Lead yourself | **Lead your people** | Lead your business | Lead the market

MAIN FOCUS

07 / Give ownership somewhere to live

PRINCIPLE 07

Responsibility becomes workable when authority, capability and support accompany it.

You can ask someone to take ownership while keeping every decision that would make ownership possible. They then carry the pressure of the outcome and wait for permission to influence it. When the work returns to you, the arrangement appears to prove that nobody else can be trusted. Before accepting that conclusion, inspect the authority you actually transferred.

Delegation begins with a result, a reason, a boundary and a person who understands the task. Explain what good looks like, what they may decide, what must be escalated and where support comes from. A deadline without these conditions can be an instruction to guess. An outcome with no boundary can expose the business to risks the person was never equipped to judge.

Ownership also changes your behaviour. If you routinely reverse decisions without explanation, answer questions addressed to the new owner or rescue work before they can respond, you teach people to wait for you. There are occasions when intervention is necessary. Name the reason and what it changes. Otherwise a transfer of responsibility becomes a ceremony followed by the old operating model.

Choose the degree of authority according to capability, consequence, reversibility and obligation. A small, reversible customer adjustment may need a standing limit. A material financial or safety decision may need formal approval. No universal percentage of founder involvement can settle this judgment. The useful question is which decisions deserve your attention and which reach you because the boundaries remain unwritten.

Treat learning as part of the handover. Demonstration, supervised practice and review require time before capacity is released. Agree when you will observe, when the person decides alone, and what would bring the work back for support. The object is reliable judgment. Fewer messages are useful evidence only when the result and risk remain acceptable.

The principle in the whole business

Lead yourself

Open last week's decisions. Mark those that genuinely required your authority and those you retained through habit or discomfort. Name what you would need to see to transfer one safely. Include the possibility that your preferred method is not the only adequate one.

Lead your people

Ask the proposed owner to explain the outcome, limits and escalation route in their own words. Compare their understanding with yours before the handover. Make sure they have the information and support needed to use the authority you describe.

Lead your business

Write three categories for one recurring decision: decides alone, decides and informs, seeks approval. Attach practical limits and exceptions. Put the agreement where the work happens. A policy nobody can find provides very little authority in the moment.

Lead the market

Introduce the new owner to customers or partners before there is a problem. Explain what they can resolve. Back the arrangement in ordinary interactions so that customers learn to trust the role rather than repeatedly bypassing it.

THE REFUND THAT WAITED FOR THE FOUNDER

Illustrative case. A support colleague can identify an incorrect charge but waits for the founder to approve every correction. Together they write the situations the colleague may resolve, a financial limit chosen for this business, and the exceptions requiring review. They examine the first cases together. The limit comes from the business's risk and economics; it is not an industry benchmark borrowed to make the policy look scientific.

Some duties remain with a qualified professional, an officer or a legally responsible person. A written delegation does not remove those obligations. Check the applicable requirements for material decisions. Where the recipient lacks capability or consent, increase support, change the scope or choose another arrangement.

The ownership agreement

Use a real role and real decisions. Set limits from your context. The table is a working agreement, not a universal delegation formula.

DECIDES ALONE	DECIDES AND INFORMS	SEEKS APPROVAL
Routine cases within agreed limits	Actions requiring visibility	Exceptions with material consequences
Write the actual decisions	Name who is informed and when	Name the approval route
Information and support available	Record the reason where useful	State what can proceed while waiting

HOW TO USE THE MODEL

Place the outcome above three authority columns. Under each column write actual decisions, information needed and exceptions. Beneath all three, name the support person and review date. This makes it possible to distinguish a capability issue from a permission issue when the next decision gets stuck.

A TEST IN THE REAL WEEK

Transfer one bounded decision and let the new owner make it. Record the result, the time taken and any avoidable return to you. Review how the judgment was reached. If you disagree, explain the reasoning rather than quietly taking the role back.

A QUESTION WORTH STAYING WITH

What can another person genuinely own, and what must I provide for that to be fair?

FIGURE 07 / ExploraSelf working model / A New Way of Winning

Turn the principle into a move

01 Name it

Name one recurring outcome that another person could own.

02 Evidence

Open the recent work record; list the decisions and waits inside that outcome.

03 Gap

Compare required authority and capability with what the person currently has.

04 Cost

Record the delay, risk or founder time created by the gap.

05 Decision

Agree the result, decision limits, support and escalation route.

06 Move

Transfer one real decision on a named date and communicate the arrangement.

07 Review

Review the outcome and reasoning together; adjust the boundary deliberately.

DO NOW	PREPARE NEXT	POSTPONE DELIBERATELY
Transfer one bounded decision with an explicit support and escalation agreement.	Develop the recipient's judgment through real decisions and reasoned feedback.	Delay a wider handover until the first decision has been made and reviewed.

WHAT YOU LEAVE WITH

A named owner, a usable authority agreement and one decision made under it.

Keep the limits beside the economic and capacity choices in Chapter 8.

08

CHAPTER

PRIMARY DOMAIN / LEAD YOUR BUSINESS

Read the cost of your promises

THE PRINCIPLE

Economic clarity protects the choices and obligations the business is meant to sustain.

Can this business afford what it promises, including the time and capacity it uses?

CONNECTED THROUGH ALL FOUR DOMAINS

Lead yourself | Lead your people | **Lead your business** | Lead the market

MAIN FOCUS

08 / Read the cost of your promises

PRINCIPLE 08

Economic clarity protects the choices and obligations the business is meant to sustain.

A growing sales total can make a founder feel safer while the business becomes harder to carry. More work may require more cash before customers pay. More revenue may arrive with a thinner contribution. More customers may consume capacity that was already fully committed. Growth deserves to be examined as an operating arrangement, rather than celebrated as a number on its own.

Begin with a defined period and a clear boundary. Revenue is the value of sales recognised for that period under the accounting method you use. Cash received is money that arrived. They may differ because of deposits, credit terms and payment timing. Record both without treating one as proof of the other. Use qualified accounting support for the reporting and tax treatment that applies to your business.

For a simple decision model, subtract costs that change with the work from sales. The remainder is contribution toward fixed operating costs and the result. Then examine the unpaid founder effort supporting it. If that effort is absent from the recorded costs, estimate an allowance separately and label it. Do not subtract paid founder compensation again. The point is to see the economic dependency, not to manufacture an official profit figure from a rough exercise.

Margin and cash answer different questions. A job may contribute toward overhead while paying too late to fund the next job. A deposit may improve cash before the work has been earned or delivered. Ask what money is available, what is committed and when each obligation falls due. A cash balance carries promises within it.

Numbers should make a choice clearer: reprice, reshape scope, reduce avoidable cost, change terms, add capacity or stop taking a particular job. They cannot choose your purpose for you. You may accept lower financial return for a stated strategic or human reason. Write the reason, the amount you can carry and the date you will reconsider it. A deliberate subsidy is a decision. An invisible one is simply difficult to manage.

The principle in the whole business

Lead yourself

Count the hours attached to a typical job, including preparation, chasing and recovery. Where founder labour is unpaid, examine what the return must support. Distinguish a consciously chosen investment period from a permanent model financed by unacknowledged personal time.

Lead your people

Ask where growth would create overtime, training needs or a new role. Include onboarding and supervision rather than treating a hire as instant capacity. Agree who carries the work before promising the customer that more can be delivered.

Lead your business

Use one currency and one consistent period. Separate contribution, operating result and cash movement. Check payment dates and obligations. Choose a reserve according to the risks you face, rather than adopting an unexplained universal number.

Lead the market

Compare scope, terms and delivery effort across actual customers. A price that appears high may support less than expected after rework and delays. Change the offer honestly, giving customers a clear account of what they receive.

MORE SALES, LESS ROOM

Illustrative example, not ExploraSelf results or a benchmark. In one month, a service sells $12,000, incurs $4,800 of variable delivery costs and $4,200 of other fixed operating costs. Contribution is $7,200; the simplified operating result is $3,000 before excluded taxes, interest and other accounting items. If 60 unpaid founder hours are valued for planning at $30, the separate allowance is $1,800. That leaves $1,200 after the allowance in this model. These assumptions must be replaced by the reader's own records.

A simplified model is not an accounting statement or a complete valuation. Cost behaviour can change with volume, and mixed offers may have different economics. Estimates should stay labelled. Seek appropriate advice for financing, tax, insolvency or material contractual decisions.

Two views of the same business

Illustrative USD figures only. The upper view concerns a simplified operating result. The lower view concerns cash timing. They are different views, not interchangeable profits.

OPERATING VIEW	USD / MONTH
Revenue	12,000
Less variable delivery costs	4,800
Contribution	7,200
Less fixed operating costs	4,200
Simplified operating result	3,000

CASH VIEW	USD / MONTH
Opening cash + receipts - payments	8,000 + 10,000 - 12,000
Closing cash	6,000

HOW TO USE THE MODEL

The same example begins with $8,000 cash, receives $10,000 and pays $12,000 during the month. Closing cash is $6,000 even though the simplified operating result is positive. Timing and the content of the receipts and payments explain the difference; the model does not specify a complete reconciliation. Find that explanation in your actual records before deciding that either figure is wrong.

A TEST IN THE REAL WEEK

If the simplified contribution ratio stayed at 60%, $4,200 of fixed operating costs would require $7,000 of sales to cover them. This uses the standard break-even relationship [R4]. The assumption of a stable mix, price and cost structure matters. It is a planning estimate, excluding the separate founder allowance and other excluded items, not a target that guarantees viability.

FIGURE 08 / ExploraSelf working model / A New Way of Winning

Turn the principle into a move

01 Name it

State the economic decision and the month or job you are examining.

02 Evidence

Open sales, cost, payment and time records; label every estimate and missing amount.

03 Gap

Identify the difference between sales, contribution, operating result and cash available.

04 Cost

Name the obligation, founder time or capacity that the current arrangement leaves unsupported.

05 Decision

Choose price, scope, cost, terms or capacity as the first lever to test.

06 Move

Make the agreed change on a named offer or job and record its assumptions.

07 Review

Compare actual delivery and receipts with the model on a set date.

DO NOW	PREPARE NEXT	POSTPONE DELIBERATELY
Build one honest job or monthly picture from your records and choose one economic lever.	Review payment timing and capacity before accepting a larger commitment.	Delay expansion commitments whose funding or delivery assumptions you cannot explain.

WHAT YOU LEAVE WITH

A labelled economic picture, a cash view and one owned decision.

Use these boundaries in the systems of Chapter 9 and growth choices of Chapter 10.

09

CHAPTER

PRIMARY DOMAIN / LEAD YOUR BUSINESS

Build systems that keep promises

THE PRINCIPLE

A useful system makes reliable work easier while preserving human judgment.

What must work consistently without depending on my memory or rescue?

CONNECTED THROUGH ALL FOUR DOMAINS

Lead yourself | Lead your people | **Lead your business** | Lead the market

MAIN FOCUS

09 / Build systems that keep promises

PRINCIPLE 09

A useful system makes reliable work easier while preserving human judgment.

A system is a set of arrangements that helps a promise survive an ordinary week. It can be as simple as a booking confirmation, a clear handoff and a check before delivery. Its value lies in the work it enables. The length of the document, the sophistication of the software and the beauty of the flowchart are secondary.

Start where the work repeatedly waits, fails or returns for correction. Follow a real job from request to completion. Identify the trigger, inputs, owner, actions, acceptance check and route for exceptions. Notice what the next person needs before the work reaches them. An internal handoff can lose context long before the customer experiences the consequence.

Write for the person who will use the instruction. Ask them to run a common case while you observe. Where they hesitate, the page has given you useful information. Correct it. A process can be clear to its author because the author supplies the missing knowledge automatically. Testing removes that private advantage.

Assign an owner who can keep the system current. Give changes a place to live, retire obsolete versions and decide who handles exceptions. A procedure without maintenance slowly becomes a historical account. People learn that reality has moved on, and the written system loses its authority.

Automate stable, understood work where the result and failure route can be checked. A machine can execute an unclear arrangement very efficiently. Before automating, ask who notices a failure, who can stop the process and how a person affected can reach help. The responsibility remains human even when the arithmetic, reminders or routing are performed by software.

The principle in the whole business

Lead yourself

Name the problem you repeatedly rescue and what you gain from being the rescuer. Examine the work record before interpreting your motive. Choose a support boundary that lets someone else act while protecting obligations that genuinely require intervention.

Lead your people

Ask the giver and receiver of a handoff to list what must travel with the work. Compare their answers. Agree the outcome, authority, information and acceptance check. Give people a way to flag a missing input without being blamed for the delay it reveals.

Lead your business

Document one common case in plain language, name the owner and test it. Track a measure close to the problem: waiting time, rework or completion against the agreed standard. Use the result to improve the arrangement.

Lead the market

Check the customer experience across the whole promise. A flawless internal step can still end in confusion if nobody explains the next action. Make the outside experience part of the acceptance check.

THE HANDOFF THAT LOOKED COMPLETE

Illustrative case. A sales team sends operations a signed agreement, but the customer's promised start date is buried in a message thread. Operations plans against a different date. They create a short handoff containing the outcome, scope, date, payment condition and owner. One job is passed through it before the form becomes standard. The improvement comes from preserved context, not a more elaborate tool.

Some work is rare, uncertain or highly specialised. Excessive standardisation can hide risks or prevent a professional from adapting. Document the boundaries and escalation route where the action itself cannot responsibly be reduced to a simple script. Maintain specialist requirements where applicable.

The promise chain

Follow a real piece of work. Every handoff needs an owner and an acceptance check; exceptions need a visible route.



EXCEPTIONS: a visible route to a person with authority

HOW TO USE THE MODEL

Place the customer promise above the chain. Under each step, write the owner and what proves the step is complete. Draw the path an exception takes. Look for a link where the next person has to infer what happened. That is a candidate for clarification before new software is added.

A TEST IN THE REAL WEEK

Choose an appropriate bounded absence or a period in which the owner runs the work without routine rescue. Set safeguards and access to help. Review the decisions and exceptions afterwards. A system's ability to support work independently is demonstrated within the conditions tested; it is not proved forever by a single successful run.

A QUESTION WORTH STAYING WITH

What must work consistently without depending on my memory or rescue?

FIGURE 09 / ExploraSelf working model / A New Way of Winning

Turn the principle into a move

01 Name it

Name the promise and recurring process that supports it.

02 Evidence

Open one completed and one troubled job; trace the actual steps and handoffs.

03 Gap

Identify the missing input, owner, authority or acceptance check.

04 Cost

Count observable delay or rework and describe the customer consequence.

05 Decision

Choose the smallest process change that addresses the demonstrated problem.

06 Move

Have the intended user run it on a real case and record corrections.

07 Review

Review the result, exceptions and owner's maintenance responsibility on a set date.

DO NOW	PREPARE NEXT	POSTPONE DELIBERATELY
Write and test one common process with the person who will use it.	Give the process an owner, version location and exception route.	Delay automation until the basic process and failure response can be explained.

WHAT YOU LEAVE WITH

One process used by someone else, corrected from the test and owned for maintenance.

Use tested capacity and reliability as evidence when choosing what grows next.

LEADING

Steward what you have built.



BUILDING GROWING SCALING LEADING

YOU ARE HERE / CHAPTERS 10-12

Carry forward from Scaling

07 / Real ownership

A named owner with clear authority, support and an escalation route.

08 / Economic clarity

A labelled economic picture that distinguishes sales, contribution and cash.

09 / A reliable system

A process used by someone else, corrected from a test and owned for maintenance.

The next three chapters

10 / Choose the growth you can stand behind

Choose what deserves to grow and what should remain enough.

11 / Grow people who can lead

Help another person develop and exercise judgment.

12 / Review, repair and hand on

Review the consequences, repair what needs repair and choose the next season.

AFTER CHAPTER 12 / REVIEW

Carry the evidence into the next season.

RETURN / CHAPTER 01

Revisit what winning is for with what you now know.

10

CHAPTER

PRIMARY DOMAIN / LEAD THE MARKET

Choose the growth you can stand behind

THE PRINCIPLE

Growth earns its place through what it makes possible and the consequences it asks people to carry.

What deserves to become bigger, and what should remain enough?

CONNECTED THROUGH ALL FOUR DOMAINS

Lead yourself | Lead your people | Lead your business | **Lead the market**

MAIN FOCUS

10 / Choose the growth you can stand behind

PRINCIPLE 10

Growth earns its place through what it makes possible and the consequences it asks people to carry.

There is a stage at which the business can supply opportunities faster than the founder can give each one proper attention. A new market, a new product, a partnership, another location: each arrives with a convincing story. The challenge becomes choosing which commitments deserve resources and which should be released, even when they are good ideas.

Return to the definition of winning. Ask what growth would make possible for customers, people, economic resilience and the life behind the business. Then ask what it would require. Additional sales can draw on delivery capacity, working cash, management attention and trust. Name the exchange before promising its benefits. An opportunity is only partly understood when its attractive side has been described.

Enough is a strategic boundary you can revisit. A founder may choose a size that supports excellent work and a meaningful life. Another may choose expansion to serve a problem that demands greater reach. Both require serious economics and responsibility. The choice should be made with evidence and intention, rather than inherited from the loudest version of entrepreneurial success.

Treat a growth direction as a hypothesis with conditions. State the customer need, the evidence of demand, the capability you can use, the investment required and what would change your mind. Where uncertainty is material, stage the commitment so that learning can arrive before the full cost. A reversible pilot is useful only if the business is willing to respond to what it reveals.

Make stopping part of the plan. Resources for the new direction must come from somewhere. If nothing stops, the cost may appear as reduced quality, unpaid time or strain on people with little power to refuse. Tell affected people what changes and why. Stop work responsibly, including customer commitments and obligations that continue after an initiative has ended.

The principle in the whole business

Lead yourself

Name the attraction of the opportunity without disguising it as a market argument. Status, curiosity and ambition can be acknowledged. Then examine whether the opportunity serves the life and contribution you chose, including the personal role it would require.

Lead your people

Ask who will carry the transition, what they need to learn and what will leave their workload. Invite operational disagreement before public commitment. People closest to delivery may see a cost the founder's excitement has omitted.

Lead your business

Compare cash, capacity, dependencies and decision load across the options. Use ranges or scenarios where uncertainty requires them, with assumptions shown. Choose an affordable first commitment and a review rule based on evidence you can actually collect.

Lead the market

Speak with customers in the proposed direction and examine behaviour as well as interest. Ask why the current alternative is insufficient. Keep claims within the capability and terms the business can support.

A SECOND LOCATION

Illustrative case. A profitable service business considers a second location. Before signing a long lease, the founder tests demand through a limited arrangement with clearly stated dates and scope. She tracks actual bookings, delivery effort and cash commitments. She also names the work the existing team will stop. The test may support expansion, redesign or staying at one location. Its value is the decision it informs.

Some opportunities have deadlines or require significant up-front commitment. A small pilot may not reproduce the economics of the full decision. State those limits. Strategic judgment still involves uncertainty, and a favourable test does not remove financing, legal or execution risk.

The growth decision gates

These are questions to answer with evidence, not pass marks. A missing answer identifies work needed before a larger commitment.

QUESTION	EVIDENCE TO BRING
Purpose	What would this make possible, and for whom?
Demand	What have relevant customers done or committed?
Economics	What must be funded, when and under which assumptions?
Capacity	Who will deliver, and what work will make room?
Commitment	What is the limit, decision date and continuation rule?

HOW TO USE THE MODEL

Work through purpose, demand, economics and capacity. Then write the first commitment and the condition for continuing. If one element remains uncertain, decide whether you can afford to learn it through action or need to pause. Every yes should identify the resource it uses and the work it displaces.

A TEST IN THE REAL WEEK

Write the evidence that would lead you to continue, adapt or stop before the pilot begins. Include a maximum commitment and a decision date. At review, read the original rule before telling the new story. Changed circumstances can justify a changed rule, but record the reason.

A QUESTION WORTH STAYING WITH

What deserves to become bigger, and what should remain enough?

FIGURE 10 / ExploraSelf working model / A New Way of Winning

Turn the principle into a move

01 Name it

Name the growth option and what it is meant to make possible.

02 Evidence

Open customer, capacity and cash records; separate evidence from assumptions.

03 Gap

Identify the weakest-supported requirement for the option to work.

04 Cost

State the affordable downside and who would carry it.

05 Decision

Choose a bounded test, a full commitment or a deliberate pause.

06 Move

Name the owner, resource limit, displaced work and start date.

07 Review

Review against the written continuation rule and communicate the decision.

DO NOW	PREPARE NEXT	POSTPONE DELIBERATELY
Put one live opportunity through purpose, demand, economics and capacity questions.	Run the smallest decision-relevant test that fits the risk and economics.	Delay expansion driven mainly by momentum while its operating exchange remains unnamed.

WHAT YOU LEAVE WITH

One growth choice with assumptions, an affordable commitment and a review rule.

Include the leadership capability required by the choice in Chapter 11.

11

CHAPTER

PRIMARY DOMAIN / LEAD YOUR PEOPLE

Grow people who can lead

THE PRINCIPLE

Leadership creates conditions in which other people can develop and exercise judgment.

Who is becoming more capable because of the way I lead?

CONNECTED THROUGH ALL FOUR DOMAINS

Lead yourself	**Lead your people**	Lead your business	Lead the market
	MAIN FOCUS		

11 / Grow people who can lead

PRINCIPLE 11

Leadership creates conditions in which other people can develop and exercise judgment.

A founder can build a team that completes tasks and still remain the only person expected to make sense of the business. The team becomes skilled at receiving decisions. The founder becomes increasingly necessary. Developing leaders changes that pattern by making reasoning, context and consequences part of the work people are trusted to carry.

Begin with a real responsibility and a willing person. Ask what they want to develop, what the role requires and what support is available. Potential is a possibility to investigate, not a promise you can make on someone else's behalf. Development should be visible in the work they practise, the authority they receive and the quality of feedback they can use.

Show how you reach a decision. Name the evidence, the uncertainty, the trade-off and the boundary. Invite a different interpretation. When you change your mind, explain what changed it. People learn very little judgment from a founder who presents conclusions as instincts available only to the founder. Making your reasoning inspectable also gives others a chance to improve it.

Move responsibility in increments that match the consequences. Someone may first observe a decision, then explain a recommendation, then act within an agreed boundary, and eventually help another person learn. This sequence is a working teaching model, not a universal developmental law. Experience, task and risk may call for a different order or more support.

Prepare succession as part of continuity. Ask what happens if the person carrying an essential area is absent, including you. A successor needs access, context, practice and appropriate authority. A name on an organisation chart does not supply those conditions. Nor does succession require that every founder leave a role they still want and can responsibly hold. It requires knowing how the business will carry its obligations if circumstances change.

The principle in the whole business

Lead yourself

Notice the situations in which you protect your status by remaining the only answer. Ask what would make another person's good judgment visible to you. Be willing to support a decision reached differently when it meets the agreed purpose and limits.

Lead your people

Discuss a specific development responsibility with the person concerned. Agree the practice, authority, feedback and review date. Ask about their ambitions rather than assuming that the path you value is the path they want.

Lead your business

Map essential responsibilities and their current holders. For one exposed area, name a continuity plan and the next learning opportunity. Protect access and security appropriately. Knowledge should be shared deliberately rather than scattered through informal permission.

Lead the market

Give emerging leaders appropriate opportunities to represent the business with customers or partners. Prepare them, clarify the boundary and review the experience. Transfer trust through supported exposure, rather than announcing a new contact and disappearing.

THE RECOMMENDATION BEFORE THE ANSWER

Illustrative case. An operations colleague asks the founder how to handle a supplier delay. Instead of answering immediately, the founder asks for the options, likely consequences and recommendation. They examine the reasoning, agree a boundary and let the colleague act. At review, they discuss what happened. The task remains real; the added value is practice in making and explaining a decision.

Coaching questions should not become a way to withhold urgent information or push risk onto someone less powerful. Give a direct answer where the situation requires it. Development is an agreement with support, not a test the person did not know they were taking.

From receiving decisions to teaching judgment

An original working progression for this manual. Adapt the steps to the task, person, obligations and risk; it is not a validated leadership scale.

OBSERVE	See the context
EXPLAIN	State the options
PROPOSE	Give a reason
OWN	Act within limits
TEACH	Help another learn

HOW TO USE THE MODEL

Place a real decision beside the progression. Identify the next useful practice rather than assigning the person a global level. Someone may lead confidently in delivery and still need to observe a financial negotiation. Capability is specific enough to develop when you describe the work, not the person as a score.

A TEST IN THE REAL WEEK

Choose a decision the learner can make within a clear limit. Before it, ask them to explain the options and recommendation. Afterwards, examine both the outcome and the reasoning. Good reasoning can meet an unfavourable outcome under uncertainty; a lucky result can conceal a poor process.

A QUESTION WORTH STAYING WITH

Who is becoming more capable because of the way I lead?

FIGURE 11 / ExploraSelf working model / A New Way of Winning

Turn the principle into a move

01 Name it

Name one responsibility and the person who wants to develop toward it.

02 Evidence

Open recent work examples and record what they can already do reliably.

03 Gap

Identify the specific judgment, information or authority still missing.

04 Cost

Describe the risk of leaving the responsibility dependent on one person.

05 Decision

Agree a real practice opportunity and the support boundary.

06 Move

Have the person exercise the responsibility on a named occasion.

07 Review

Review the reasoning and result together; choose the next practice.

DO NOW	PREPARE NEXT	POSTPONE DELIBERATELY
Agree one development responsibility with a willing person and support one real decision.	Build continuity in the most exposed essential role.	Delay titles or succession promises until scope, willingness and support have been discussed.

WHAT YOU LEAVE WITH

A practical development agreement and one decision used for learning.

Bring the continuity plan and your own example into the review of Chapter 12.

12

CHAPTER

PRIMARY DOMAIN / ALL FOUR DOMAINS

Review, repair and hand on

THE PRINCIPLE

Integrity includes examining consequences and changing the arrangement when reality requires it.

What should continue through me, what must change, and what can I help others carry?

CONNECTED THROUGH ALL FOUR DOMAINS

Lead yourself | Lead your people | Lead your business | Lead the market

12 / Review, repair and hand on

PRINCIPLE 12

Integrity includes examining consequences and changing the arrangement when reality requires it.

A review is where your intention meets the life it helped create. Look at the work, the money, the relationships and the person who has been carrying them. Some results will deserve gratitude. Some will require repair. Some will remain uncertain. The task is to make an honest account without turning the meeting into either a celebration that avoids the cost or a prosecution that ignores the good.

Compare the promise, the action and the consequence. Distinguish what you controlled from the conditions you faced, and examine both. Responsibility is strongest when it is specific. You may need to acknowledge a poor decision, support someone who carried its effects, change a system or stop a commitment. A general promise to do better leaves too much work for other people to interpret.

Repair has several parts: name what happened, recognise the effect, make an appropriate correction and change what can reasonably prevent repetition. An apology can belong within that work. It does not complete it by itself. Nor can every loss be undone. Where restoration is limited, honesty about the limit is part of the responsibility.

Legacy begins in what people learn to expect from you now. A company that pays properly, tells the truth, develops its people and delivers useful work has already made a contribution, even if it never becomes famous. Its wider effects deserve examination too: the communities it touches, the resources it uses and the incentives it creates. Economic strength and human consequence belong in the same review.

The founder's task may change again. You might remain close to the craft, lead through others, transfer ownership or end a venture responsibly. None of those decisions can be settled by a single image of success. Return to what winning is for, the obligations still in force and the evidence of what the business can carry. Then choose the next season with a clearer account than the one you had before.

The principle in the whole business

Lead yourself

Read your original definition of winning beside the last quarter's calendar. Name what has become more aligned and what has drifted. Choose one behaviour to carry forward. Ask a trusted person for an example that might challenge your account.

Lead your people

Review commitments with the people affected. Ask what became easier, what remained costly and what you failed to notice. Thank people specifically. Make repairs with owners and dates rather than asking everyone to reset their feelings on command.

Lead your business

Gather the operating rhythm, owners, economic picture and exception record. Identify what now works and what is still dependent on an untested assumption. Choose a small number of priorities the actual capacity can support.

Lead the market

Compare the public promise with customer experience and repeat business where applicable. Examine complaints and lost customers without treating every departure as proof of failure. Decide what evidence should shape the next promise.

THE QUARTER THAT GREW SALES AND STRAINED TRUST

Illustrative case. A founder reaches a sales goal while the team absorbs repeated late changes. In review, she keeps the commercial learning and acknowledges the delivery cost. The next quarter includes a scope-change rule, a named delivery owner and a reduced initiative list. She also repairs an unpaid commitment. Success is examined as a whole arrangement, so the lesson can travel forward without repeating the hidden bill.

A review should not require someone to disclose private experiences or agree with the founder's interpretation. Respect consent, confidentiality and the power in the room. Some issues need a separate process. A quarterly meeting is also too slow for urgent safety, cash or conduct problems; address them when they arise.

The living review loop

Review returns you to a better-informed commitment. It is part of everyday leadership and can be used at different time scales.



HOW TO USE THE MODEL

Put the original commitment beside the evidence, name the consequence, decide what continues or changes, and assign the repair or next action. Carry the revised commitment into the next cycle. Keep a dated record so that the same lesson does not have to be rediscovered in a new conversation.

A TEST IN THE REAL WEEK

Ask someone outside the plan to read the one-page account back to you. What do they believe the priority is, who owns it and what will be checked? Their questions reveal where clarity still lives in your head. Rewrite the page where it fails that test.

A QUESTION WORTH STAYING WITH

What should continue through me, what must change, and what can I help others carry?

FIGURE 12 / ExploraSelf working model / A New Way of Winning

Turn the principle into a move

01 Name it

State the commitment or period you are reviewing.

02 Evidence

Gather the original plan, actual results, time record and accounts of those affected.

03 Gap

Name the difference between intention and consequence, including uncertainty.

04 Cost

Describe what the difference cost and what value was genuinely created.

05 Decision

Choose what to continue, stop, repair or test next.

06 Move

Assign each action an owner and date; communicate the changes to those affected.

07 Review

Set the next review and name what would show the repair or new commitment is holding.

DO NOW	PREPARE NEXT	POSTPONE DELIBERATELY
Complete one honest review and carry out the first repair or changed commitment.	Assemble a ninety-day plan that joins purpose, people, economics and delivery.	Delay a new initiative that competes with an unresolved material obligation.

WHAT YOU LEAVE WITH

A clear account, a completed first repair and a one-page plan for the next season.

Return to Chapter 1 with evidence. The purpose can deepen; the responsibility continues.

Building / principles behind the work

The twelve existing levels remain a complete stage-specific application route. This reference identifies the most direct supporting book chapter for each level. The association is editorial and often several principles apply. It does not rename, remove or unlock any online exercise.

LEVEL	EXISTING LEVEL NAME	BOOK CHAPTER
01	Count your week	04 / Give your attention a job
02	Why it exists, in one line	01 / Decide what winning is for
03	Your client, by name	03 / Meet reality and make a useful promise
04	Price your hour	08 / Read the cost of your promises
05	Their yes, in their words	03 / Meet reality and make a useful promise
06	The 3 talks you're avoiding	06 / Tell the truth with care
07	A week you chose	04 / Give your attention a job
08	Your offer, tested	03 / Meet reality and make a useful promise
09	Out of your head	09 / Build systems that keep promises
10	Your first hundred	03 / Meet reality and make a useful promise
11	The truth you avoided	06 / Tell the truth with care
12	Your next 90 days, on one page	12 / Review, repair and hand on

Every supplied level works all four domains through the same seven clarity points. Use the workbook to record its specific answers. Use the book to understand the judgment, context and consequences behind the move.

Growing / principles behind the work

The twelve existing levels remain a complete stage-specific application route. This reference identifies the most direct supporting book chapter for each level. The association is editorial and often several principles apply. It does not rename, remove or unlock any online exercise.

LEVEL	EXISTING LEVEL NAME	BOOK CHAPTER
01	Only you, on one list	04 / Give your attention a job
02	Hire on paper first	07 / Give ownership somewhere to live
03	Fix what breaks first	09 / Build systems that keep promises
04	Say the hard thing	06 / Tell the truth with care
05	Define “finished”	05 / Make your values operational
06	Five customers, one phrase	03 / Meet reality and make a useful promise
07	Write the unwritten deal	07 / Give ownership somewhere to live
08	Your week, on one page	04 / Give your attention a job
09	Remove one brick	02 / Become someone you can rely on
10	Fix the failing handoff	09 / Build systems that keep promises
11	Trust, checked	05 / Make your values operational
12	Your business, on one page	12 / Review, repair and hand on

Every supplied level works all four domains through the same seven clarity points. Use the workbook to record its specific answers. Use the book to understand the judgment, context and consequences behind the move.

Scaling / principles behind the work

The twelve existing levels remain a complete stage-specific application route. This reference identifies the most direct supporting book chapter for each level. The association is editorial and often several principles apply. It does not rename, remove or unlock any online exercise.

LEVEL	EXISTING LEVEL NAME	BOOK CHAPTER
01	Two decisions given away	07 / Give ownership somewhere to live
02	Who could do your job	11 / Grow people who can lead
03	A system with a new owner	09 / Build systems that keep promises
04	Find the next demand	10 / Choose the growth you can stand behind
05	The talk your team avoids	06 / Tell the truth with care
06	One number, read weekly	08 / Read the cost of your promises
07	Your bet, tested small	10 / Choose the growth you can stand behind
08	Grow one leader	11 / Grow people who can lead
09	Stop one thing	10 / Choose the growth you can stand behind
10	Your edge, proven	03 / Meet reality and make a useful promise
11	What success is for	01 / Decide what winning is for
12	Held together, handed on	12 / Review, repair and hand on

Every supplied level works all four domains through the same seven clarity points. Use the workbook to record its specific answers. Use the book to understand the judgment, context and consequences behind the move.

Leading is developed in book Chapters 10-12 as a further stewardship lens. No separate fourth workbook or live online route is implied.

Choose a quarter you can actually carry

A ninety-day plan is a set of chosen commitments with enough room for delivery and learning. Begin with the definition of winning and the evidence of the current situation. Choose an outcome that would address the real constraint or protect an important obligation. Then identify the conditions the outcome needs across all four domains.

For yourself, name the behaviour and attention the quarter requires. For people, name the agreements, support and authority. For the business, name the money, capacity and system changes. For the market, name the customer evidence and promise. These are connected parts of one plan. A sales objective without delivery capacity creates work for a future crisis.

Choose a small set of priorities the actual capacity can support. There is no universal correct number. Order them so that the first remains clear when the week becomes difficult. List what will stop or wait, including the continuing obligations that still have to be honoured. Give every priority an owner, an initial move and a review date.

Choose measures close enough to the work to inform a decision. For a repeated handoff failure, examine the missing input or rework. For an uncertain offer, examine relevant customer behaviour and delivery economics. A single measure can concentrate attention, but important constraints still need watching. Do not let a convenient headline number conceal cash, quality or human cost.

Write what would make you change the plan. A material assumption may fail; a new obligation may arrive. Review enables adaptation without making every difficult week a reason to abandon the direction. At the end of the quarter, compare the original commitment with the evidence, carry out the repairs and choose the next season.

AN EXAMPLE OF A USABLE PRIORITY

Illustrative: make the customer handoff dependable. The named delivery owner will test a revised form on the next three jobs, record missing information and rework, and review it with sales on an agreed date. The number of test jobs is a chosen exercise scope, not a benchmark for process reliability.

The quarter, on one page

Use your own evidence and dates. This page is an action plan, not a scoring form.

WHAT WINNING IS FOR

The life, useful value and obligations this quarter should serve.

ONE CHOSEN OUTCOME

Current evidence / desired change / why this deserves the quarter.

THE FOUR DOMAINS

Yourself: behaviour and attention. People: agreement and support. Business: money and delivery. Market: customer and promise.

PRIORITIES, OWNERS AND FIRST MOVES

Order / owner / first action / date / evidence to review.

WHAT STOPS OR WAITS

Name the displaced work and who needs to know.

REVIEW AND REPAIR

Review date / people present / evidence / condition for changing the plan.

Teach judgment through real work

The twelve chapters can serve as twelve core teaching modules. Each joins a principle, four domain applications, a worked situation, an original visual and fieldwork. Learners can apply the same module to different business stages without requiring twelve more chapters for every stage.

A practical session pattern

Prepare

Read the chapter and bring an appropriately anonymised piece of evidence: a calendar, offer, delivery record or agreement.

Examine

Describe the situation before interpreting it. Separate facts, assumptions, interests and constraints. Invite a plausible alternative explanation.

Decide

Use the four domains to test a proposed move. Name the trade-off, authority, resources and possible consequence.

Act

Agree a proportionate action the learner can carry out in their own context. Put the owner and date in writing.

Review

Return to evidence from the action. Examine reasoning as well as outcome. Record what changed and what still needs learning.

What to assess

Look for a traceable account of the situation, a clear distinction between evidence and assumption, a reasoned decision, attention to affected people and an honest review. A commercially favourable outcome can contain poor reasoning or luck; an unfavourable outcome can still produce responsible learning. Ask the learner to explain that distinction.

Respect consent and confidentiality. Learners should not need to reveal private accounts or personal experiences to prove seriousness. Use illustrative cases where real evidence cannot be shared. Adapt the workload and support to the people and context. No university endorsement, accreditation or validated assessment is claimed for this book.

Where the ideas stand

Research informs particular ideas; it does not validate the twelve-chapter system or predict an individual founder's outcome. The book's principles and diagrams are normative working aids.

R1 / MOTIVATION AND CONDITIONS

Ryan, R. M., & Deci, E. L. (2000). Self-Determination Theory and the Facilitation of Intrinsic Motivation, Social Development, and Well-Being. American Psychologist, 55(1), 68-78. DOI: 10.1037/0003-066X.55.1.68. Used in Chapter 2 for autonomy, competence and relatedness.

R2 / SPEAKING UP AND LEARNING

Edmondson, A. (1999). Psychological Safety and Learning Behavior in Work Teams. Administrative Science Quarterly, 44(2), 350-383. DOI: 10.2307/2666999. Used in Chapter 6 for the association between psychological safety and learning behaviour in the studied teams.

R3 / ACTING UNDER UNCERTAINTY

Sarasvathy, S. D. (2001). Causation and Effectuation: Toward a Theoretical Shift from Economic Inevitability to Entrepreneurial Contingency. Academy of Management Review, 26(2), 243-263. DOI: 10.5465/AMR.2001.4378020. Used in Chapter 3 as a theoretical distinction between prediction and controllable commitments.

R4 / BREAK-EVEN ARITHMETIC

U.S. Small Business Administration. Break-even point calculator. The standard single-product relationship is fixed costs divided by price less variable cost per unit; the sales-value form uses the contribution margin ratio. Used in Chapter 8 with stated simplifications.

ExploraSelf source material

The Founder's Blueprint: Building (79 pages), Growing (77 pages), Scaling (80 pages); Personal Leadership LAB Workbook; The Founder's Manual author sample; 100 Additional Leadership Frameworks. Link to Lead programme source: Exploraself/linktolead, main branch, reviewed 27 October 2026. The programme connections in this book identify supporting principles; the existing application routes retain their own exercise sequences.

References are provided for verification and further reading. External sources retain their own rights. Cases, planning illustrations and working visuals were written for this manual; no independent validation of the combined method is claimed.

The next honest move

WHEN THIS IS THE QUESTION	RETURN TO
What is all this for?	01 / Decide what winning is for
I cannot rely on my own routine.	02 / Become someone you can rely on
I do not know whether my offer works.	03 / Meet reality and make a useful promise
Everything takes my time.	04 / Give your attention a job
We disagree about what good means.	05 / Make your values operational
I keep avoiding a conversation.	06 / Tell the truth with care
People keep waiting for me.	07 / Give ownership somewhere to live
Sales are growing but money feels tight.	08 / Read the cost of your promises
The same work keeps breaking.	09 / Build systems that keep promises
We have too many possible directions.	10 / Choose the growth you can stand behind
Nobody else can carry the judgment.	11 / Grow people who can lead
We need an honest account and a next season.	12 / Review, repair and hand on

Build something you can stand behind

The world is shaped through ordinary arrangements as well as great announcements: work that is useful, agreements that are fair, promises that can be funded, and people whose judgment is allowed to grow. Your part may be small in public view and substantial in the lives it touches.

Choose one situation. Find the record. Name the cost. Make the decision you can responsibly own. Let the action enter the week, and return to learn what it changed. A life with meaning is lived through such commitments. So is a business worth leading.

Lead yourself. Grow your business. Carry the responsibility well.

Your next move starts here

Take one useful question out of the book and into your life and business. Choose the invitation that serves the work in front of you. Scan a code or click its card.

01

Start Link to Lead

Put the principles to work in the Founder's Blueprint.

linktolead.exploraself.com/start/

02

Explore ExploraSelf

Discover the books, tools and programmes for your next step.

exploraself.com

03

Read Unshakeable

Explore the Personal Leadership Manual and its resources.

exploraself.com/unshakeable

04

Find your North Star

Bring your numbers and leadership questions into a practical plan.

linktolead.exploraself.com/northstar/

EXPLORASELF

A GOOD PEOPLE COMPANY

WIN IN A WAY YOU CAN STAND BEHIND.

A New Way of Winning equips the person behind the business to choose clearly, build responsibly and lead with meaning.

Twelve principles connect the life of the founder with the people, decisions, economics and promises that shape a business. Return to them when you need to know what matters, what comes next and what deserves to wait.

- **Lead yourself**
- **Lead your people**
- **Lead your business**
- **Lead the market**

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